



Simulated training of extra vehicular activity in the Mars500

delay was built into communications with the control centre to simulate an interplanetary mission and the crew has been given almost an identical diet to that used for the International Space Station.

As with a human spaceflight mission, the crew was free to take certain personal items, and they were supplied with books, films, personal lap-

tops and can occupy themselves with physical exercise or their own studies.

During the isolation period, the candidates simulated all elements of the Mars mission, travelling to Mars, orbiting the planet, landing and return to Earth.

The crew was very self-reliant, organising themselves a great deal of their daily tasks. They were responsible for monitoring and maintaining the health and psychological states of themselves and each other; monitoring and controlling and maintaining systems, including life support, control resource consumption, carry out standard and non-standard cleaning and maintenance, as well as fulfilling scientific investigations.

During simulated 'Mars surface operations', the crew was divided into two groups of three people each. Once the first group 'descended' to the Martian surface, the hatch between the Martian simulation module and the rest of the facility was closed by the second group and was opened again only when the Mars surface stay simulation ended.

On November 4, 2011, Mars500's six brave volunteers stepped out of their 'spacecraft' to be welcomed by the waiting scientists – happy that the venture had worked even better than expected.

The actual mission to Mars would still be a long time away, but the success of the Mars500 project has been a step in the right direction to exploring new worlds... **d**

"If somebody had said before the flight, 'Are you going to get carried away looking at the earth from the moon?' I would have said, 'No, no way.' But yet when I first looked back at the earth, standing on the moon, I cried."

Alan Shepard, the American astronaut who had already become the first American in space, many years before stepping on the moon.